

One of the worst fires in the history of Kolkata shows norms are being brazenly flouted for commercial gains and many such disasters are waiting to happen

■ By Swagata Sen

Even 100 metres away from the scene of billowing smoke and lapping flames, the stench of burnt plastic is strong in the air. Traders in and around Brabourne Road in Kolkata's Burrabazar try to pick the threads of their daily life from the charred remains of their business. India's largest wholesale market has already lost six days of trade worth several crores, and most of the merchants are impatient to get back in the saddle. A little further down the road, that ends in a flyover connecting Howrah Bridge with Kolkata, Nandaram Market, one of the tallest buildings in Burrabazar with its illegal 13 floors has turned a seething black monster. The fire has been doused, but it will be a while before the embers die down.

It was one of the most ferocious and badly-managed fires in the history of Kolkata after the 1997 blaze at the city book fair. It took 300 firemen, a 40-odd group of Army personnel, a hydraulic ladder, and 45 fire engines more than 100 hours to finally douse the fire over four days after it broke out on the midnight of January 11 and engulfed the 12 properties of the 2,000-odd traders who worked there.

The burnt floors of Nandaram, which mostly housed godowns, contained everything from huge stocks of textiles and tarpauline to gunny bags filled with plastic zippers, buttons, thread, and other combustible material. Worse still, the building had an illegal generator room on the 12th floor which stocked diesel and LPG cylinders that added fuel to the fire. Local MLA Mohammad Sohrabuddin has put the estimated figure of loss at Rs 600 crore due to the blaze.

Burrabazar is one of the biggest centres of the illegal money transfer syndicate, popularly known as hawala. Most of the trading here is done verbally. From rent agreements, sales deals to money lending, nothing has any paperwork involved, and thus, there is no insurance. Here, *kachcha* or black money changes hands without any paperwork, the fee for every lakh being Rs 100, and the only marker for the money is the series of numbers on the piles of notes.

Om Prakash Poddar, an ex-councillor, whose garment trading shop has been gutted, says the fire has affected at least 30,000 people indirectly. Behind the veneer of godowns, it has been estimated that goods worth

FLAME TAMED, FEAR LOOMS:
Firefighters try to douse the fire (right); a trader mourns his losses



more than Rs 2,500 crore have been destroyed, burnt to ashes in the building itself. Nandaram had caught fire earlier in March 2002 as well, but no remedial firefighting measures were put in place even after that.

The fire this time began from a shack in the Jamuna Lal Street. The first fire engine arrived well over an hour later. Soon, more fire tenders arrived, but the area behind the shacks which caught fire was almost inaccessible. By the next night, the flames had spread to the Kashiram market and by noon on January 13, they had reached the 13th floor of Nandaram. The firemen, however, could only reach till the sixth floor, that too on one side of the building since the other three sides were inaccessible due to the congested market area. The fire department was also caught napping with faulty



DEADLY

equipment. It was only after three days, when a hydraulic ladder arrived from the Haldia Petrochemical plant, that they could finally reach the top floors of the building. After some initial dilly-dallying, the army was called in to bring the situation under control. To add insult to the injury, the state Government has not yet announced any compensation for those affected by the fire.

With an administration that allows the city's commercial buildings to flout norms, such disasters are waiting to happen. Coupled with this are the spiralling property prices and the demand for malls in Kolkata, where a